

TALKING TOUGH

REFUSING TO BE ARM TWISTED BY THE LEFT ANY LONGER, A POLITICALLY TRANSFORMED MANMOHAN SINGH TAKES ON AN IDEOLOGICALLY RADICAL PRAKASH KARAT. IT IS A FIGHT ON WHICH HANGS THE FUTURE OF THE GOVERNMENT.

■ By Satarupa Bhattachariya and Priya Sahgal

It is a nuclear face-off between two believers. For Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, the Civil Nuclear Energy Cooperation Agreement with the United States is a historic moment in India's engagement with the world—and its evolution as a power. For him, it is the logical extension of India's success as a liberal market economy, and the strategic pact between the world's largest and the mightiest democracies is a celebration of national interest. It is a deal consecrated by his conviction. And he is talking tough for its full realisation, ready to fight for it, willing to risk the stability of his Government for a cause. For Prakash Karat, the no-nonsensical apparatchik-in-chief of CPI(M), the deal is nothing short of an imperialist con on a gullible India.

For him, it is an abdication of national sovereignty, and India will be a better place without this sham.

The confrontation turned almost explosive when the prime minister, known for his quiet patience and understatement, decided to call the Left's bluff. Enough was enough, and who would like to be painted in Soviet red as a poodle of imperial Washington? The deal is not renegotiable, he maintained, and if the comrades don't want to support the Government, they may very well go for a separation. Aggression has never been Manmohan's style, frankly. Taken aback by this unexpected ballistic retort, Karat had to hit back: "It is not up to us to withdraw support, but for the prime minister to decide if he wants to run the Government." To be fair, Karat was